

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Chip Fabbing

If you have a one-track mind that thinks chips and wafers are only about food, think again. There's a lot of jargon you've probably heard every day that applies to the manufacture of chips (the silicon kind you put in gadgets), too.

Fab: 1. *v.* To "fabricate" chips once they've been designed. E.g. "*These designs are ready to be fabbed.*" (also see *foundry*). 2. *n.* The production system itself—"*Did you hear about AMD's new fab line in <insert city name here>?*"

Note: Should never be interpreted as "fabulous."

65nm *n.* : The latest chip manufacturing process. The name means that the transistors on the chip are 65 nanometres (a billionth of a metre) wide. For reference, your hair is about 80,000 nanometres thick.

Nanoacre *n.* : An area about 2 square millimetres on a chip design—the smallest acre. Really, though, a nanoacre can cost as much as an acre of land if you factor in all the expenses.

Foundry *n.* : The company that does the fabbing. Few chip design companies have their own foundries—these facilities eat up billions of dollars just by existing.

Wafer *n.* : What results when you cut up a silicon crystal into thin slices. Chips are built on wafers. **Note:** These wafers are inedible, and perhaps even toxic.

Doping *v.* : The process of adding silicon to make it conduct electrons better—in its pure form, silicon is about as useful as the sand it's made from. So if you hear someone talking about "doping silicon," the connotation isn't as negative as it might seem.

And now, the best way to explain away a chip malfunction:

Magic Smoke *n.* : A supposedly magical blue smoke that is present inside all chips and keeps them from going "poof!". E.g. "It failed? All right, WHO let out the magic smoke?"

Give us this day our daily fix

It's been a while since a gaming addiction has infested these halls—no, really—a *true* gaming addiction with obstacles to productivity and everything. The start of the month saw Raaabo and Nimish satisfying the urge to blow each other's cars up and compare Long Jump scores in Crashday till the wee hours, with the occasional guest appearance from SKOAR! editor Badri. Raaabo still continues to shatter world records in Long Jump 1 (477m, should you care to try breaking it).

Editor Deepak spent a week at CeBIT, Hannover, causing mixed emotions—jealousy, of course, at the fact that the rest of us didn't get to go to Geek Heaven, but there was also much joy and lawlessness that prevailed in his absence.

Apparently CeBIT is too much for one man to take—the size of the event boggled

his mind to the extent that he even forgot his own BIOS password when he returned ("Someone changed it!" he still insists).

We promised a follow-up on this—Raaabo and Nimish finally got the 5.4 GB NASA image of the Earth to open in Photoshop as a Photoshop RAW, but the battle is only half-won. The image opens fine in greyscale, but still stubbornly refuses to show its true colours. Then one day, Raaabo wondered why the image filled up *exactly* all the free space that was left on his hard drive when he extracted it: "What if it didn't extract properly? There could've been an error, but maybe we didn't notice it." Quick searches revealed the absence of the original compressed download, halting

progress on this front for now. The two are taking a breather from this obsession, but something tells us this isn't the end of this quest.

DIGIT DIARY

WEIRD NEWS

Google's World Domination Plans!

More plans to dominate the world: if you thought the earlier story about Japanese company NTT making devices to control human movement was a step forward towards world dominance, think again! As of now only two companies show promise in the "taking-over-the-world" category: the current world rulers Microsoft, and the younger challengers called Sergey Brin and Larry Page. Since Microsoft's dominance is old and boring, let's look at how Google plans to overthrow the Redmond-based giant...

The Register (www.theregister.co.uk) recently published an article based on a photograph (see image alongside) of plans on a whiteboard in "Building 43" which, as *The Register* claims, is the "cyber-equivalent of Area 51"! Though a little jumbled and messy, the poorly-constructed plans on the whiteboard actually seem to be a plan to establish

"orbital mind control," whatever that means.

The plan may be a little too complex to explain here, but we can still get a rough idea of what Google has supposedly planned:

1. Buy New Zealand
 2. Set up shop in a volcano
 3. Launch a spy satellite
 4. Launch Orbital Mind Control
 5. Create clean fuel
 6. Make the Google Football Club
 7. Develop Google OS
 8. Provide the world with 100 per cent accurate weather forecasts
 9. Make robots that have AI and can repair broken computers and finally,
 10. (Our interpretation) Rule the world!
- Sounds simple enough! Well, since we're not even sure that this has

actually come from Google, there's nothing much to say. However, the one thing we have to proclaim is that whoever drew this brain map may be a genius, and perhaps evil as well, but if Google's stock market results are anything to go by, it may be a few decades before Google even attempts a coup on good ol' Bill!

"IPODS CAUSE HEARING LOSS!"

Pump Down The Volume

There's news, then there's stupid news. We've already learnt to trust Americans grab by the b***s any opportunity to sue, and recently, Apple was sued by a US man who says his iPod can cause loss of

